

The more things change...

An embarrassing thing happened this month: while proof reading one of the articles you will read in this month's issue, I noticed that a snippet (those little stories on top of the page) was repeated. We have our own way of trying to ensure that this doesn't happen, and it involves everyone uploading snippets to a Google doc, and the layout people mark what they have used for the magazine. I went to Google Drive, searched for "August Snippets", and clicked on the first link I saw. Most of the snippets were marked as placed already, and I was skimming through the news when I had a sense of déjà vu. "Why does all this news sound familiar" I asked the guys, and they told me, "You're not shared on the snippet document yet; what are you reading?" Long story short I was reading the snippets of the August 2012 issue, and everyone had a good laugh.

However, what struck me as odd was that even though it was all last year's news, there was a recurring theme that fooled my mind into believing that it was current enough to be this month's document. The companies were all the same – Microsoft, Amazon, Facebook, Intel, Adobe, Samsung, Apple, Google, ARM, Sony...

The stories are also the same: everyone's always on the verge of releasing the Next Big Thing™, and everyone's research is "ground-breaking". Company X bought Y, new phones and tablets released, Android version X is amazing, iOS X is even better, Windows hopes to gain some ground, apps rule the roost, etc.

None of those products we were looking forward to last year left any lasting impressions. It's all just very fast flowing water travelling under the bridge that is you (the buyer). Now and then you pick up something of value, but most of it is just the cacophony of a thousand voices demanding your attention in the technology fish market.

It's always the big guys that the focus is on though. All of us watch them like hawks, to see what we can expect of them next, because they're the ones with real spending power to push things through R&D and out into the market.

This month's cover feature looks at the bigwigs of the technology world, and takes you through a short history lesson, before telling you what to expect from them in the near future. We're definitely going to be talking

about them for years to come anyway, because they have a hold on us consumers. It was just coincidence that we realised that using the first letter of their names made up the acronym M.A.F.I.A. S.A.G.A.S. Thus the storytelling style of the first cover story.

Although we're not calling them Mafia, or associating them with crime in any way, it is still pretty startling how easy it is to associate the big companies with the famous Mafia families of the 1900s. They're all struggling to gain ground over each other, wrestle control out of the hands of one another, make sinful amounts of money, and sometimes even collaborate and work together to bring down a third family (company). It's just business, as they say.

Actually, looking back at the over 12 years of technology coverage that Digit's done, it really is all the same. Sure we went from PCs to laptops, then on to mobiles and tablets, and the web wars have always been ongoing, instead of software and services, it's now all social online – but it's the overall plot that is similar.

Company X is ruling the roost, while an upstart company Y is threatening its dominance. Sometimes Y wins, sometimes X prevails, and then the story starts all over again with the victor pitted against a new company Z. Sometimes it's just two rivals, and at others it's 10 companies battling it out...

* Yawn *

This plotline is unchanging and unwavering, no matter what the technology vertical, and applies to all the success and failure stories you've ever heard of in technology.

Personally, it's new technologies that excite me, not companies or their products. Nanotechnology, robotics, mind-controlled prosthetics, etc., are the real areas of interest for me – technology advances are ever-lasting, companies are temporary!

Maybe this is just me looking to justify a stupid blunder of opening a year-old document, or maybe, the more things change, the more they stay the same... you be the judge. 



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